SOMUN HYD

8th Edition

United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime

(UNODC)

BACKGROUND GUIDE

AGENDA

Addressing the Transnational Trafficking and Illicit Production of Synthetic Narcotic Drugs and Firearms

Executive Board

Shreyansh, Chairperson | Varun, Vice-Chairperson | Akshita, Rapporteur

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1. Letter from the Executive Board

Honourable Delegates,

Welcome to the **United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC)** at the **8th edition of SOMUN HYD**. We are glad to have you in this committee, and we hope the next few days challenge you, teach you something new and leave you with lasting memories.

This agenda asks you to look at two of the most profitable illicit markets in the world together: **synthetic drugs and firearms**. They move along the same routes, are run by overlapping networks, and fuel the same cycles of violence, corruption and instability. Behind every seizure statistic is a family, a community or a state struggling to cope, and we want you to keep that human side in mind while you debate.

This guide is a **starting point, not a substitute for research**. Use it to understand the issue, then build your country's position from primary sources: official statements, national laws, treaty status and voting history. Delegates who know their own policy well, and can defend it with evidence, will always stand out.

A research-centric committee. UNODC is an **office**, not a political chamber. Its authority comes from its data, its research and its technical expertise, not from the power to command states. The World Drug Report, the Global SMART Programme and the Global Study on Firearms Trafficking are what make UNODC influential, and we expect this committee to work the same way. Every argument you make should rest on **verifiable evidence**: seizure data, treaty texts, INCB findings, national legislation and official government positions. Know where your numbers come from, be ready to cite them when challenged, and clearly separate **established fact from allegation or opinion**. Points of information, rebuttals and clauses that are grounded in research will carry far more weight with the Executive Board than rhetoric alone.

We expect three things from you in committee. First, **substance**: precise facts, not vague generalities. Second, **diplomacy**: listen to other blocs, negotiate and build consensus instead of only reading out speeches. Third, **solutions**: clear, creative and realistic clauses that fit what UNODC can actually do. Remember that this committee makes recommendations and builds cooperation, so aim for ideas that states could genuinely implement.

The Executive Board is here to help. If something in the guide or the rules of procedure is unclear, please ask us. Do not be afraid to speak, to make mistakes or to try something new. Every good delegate started as a nervous first-timer.

We look forward to a high-quality, respectful and memorable debate, and we wish you the very best for your preparation.

Warm regards,
Shreyansh, Chairperson
Varun, Vice-Chairperson
Akshita, Rapporteur

2. About the Committee

2.1 The United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime

UNODC was established in 1997 and is **headquartered in Vienna**, with field and regional offices around the world. It helps Member States fight illicit drugs, organized crime, corruption and terrorism through **three pillars**:

- **Research and analysis:** collecting and publishing data so that policy is based on evidence.
- **Normative work:** helping states draft, ratify and implement laws and treaties.
- **Technical assistance:** training, equipment and expert support in the field.

UNODC is the guardian of the **main international drug control conventions** and of the **UN Convention against Transnational Organized Crime (UNTOC)** and its protocols, including the **Firearms Protocol**. It also publishes flagship reports such as the **World Drug Report** and the **Global Study on Firearms Trafficking**.

2.2 What the Committee Can and Cannot Do

UNODC cannot force a state to act. Its outcomes are recommendations, frameworks and cooperation mechanisms. Your resolution should be realistic about this: propose **capacity building, information sharing, joint operations, funding and legal harmonisation**, not sanctions or enforcement the body cannot deliver.

2.3 Governing Bodies

Commission on Crime Prevention and Criminal Justice (CCPCJ). Established by ECOSOC in 1992, the CCPCJ is the main UN policy-making body on crime prevention and criminal justice and the governing body of UNODC's crime programme. It has **40 Member States**, elected by ECOSOC for three-year terms, and meets annually.

Commission on Narcotic Drugs (CND). Established by ECOSOC in 1946, the CND is the main UN policy-making body on drug-related matters and the governing body of UNODC's drug programme. It has **53 Member States**, elected by ECOSOC for four-year terms, and holds its main session each March. Importantly, the CND **votes on adding substances to the international control schedules**, usually on the recommendation of the World Health Organization (for drugs) or the International Narcotics Control Board (for precursors).

3. Introduction to the Agenda

Agenda: ***Addressing the Transnational Trafficking and Illicit Production of Synthetic Narcotic Drugs and Firearms***

3.1 Understanding the Agenda

The agenda has **three moving parts**, and a strong resolution will address all three:

- **Transnational trafficking:** the cross-border movement of drugs, precursor chemicals, firearms, parts and ammunition. Trafficking is what turns a local crime into an international problem, because no single state can control a supply chain that crosses five borders.
- **Illicit production:** manufacturing outside the law, from clandestine drug laboratories to unregistered, converted or homemade firearms. Production is the point where the illicit product is created, and therefore one of the most effective places to intervene.
- **Synthetic narcotics and firearms together:** the argument that these markets **reinforce one another**, so a response that treats them in isolation will fall short.

Delegates should note the word **"synthetic"**. The agenda is not a general debate on all drugs. Plant-based drugs such as cocaine, heroin and cannabis are relevant only where they connect to synthetic markets, for example where trafficking groups shift from heroin to methamphetamine, or where cocaine routes are reused for synthetic opioids. Similarly, the agenda is concerned with **illicit** firearms. The legal arms trade between states is relevant mainly where it leads to **diversion** into illicit hands.

3.2 Why This Matters

- **Synthetic drugs need no farmland.** They can be made in small labs anywhere from chemical precursors, which makes them harder to detect and eradicate than plant-based drugs like opium or cocaine. Satellite surveys of poppy and coca fields, which have guided policy for decades, are of little use against a lab in a warehouse.
- **Firearms trafficking arms criminal groups, insurgents and traffickers,** raising the cost of enforcement for every state. Firearms are used in a large share of homicides worldwide, and illicit weapons allow criminal groups to challenge police, intimidate communities and control territory.
- **Both markets are tied to money laundering, corruption and weak governance.** Profits are laundered through trade, real estate, cash businesses and, increasingly, cryptocurrency. Corruption of customs, police and licensing officials is often what allows both drugs and weapons to pass.
- **The impacts are human:** overdose deaths, addiction, armed violence, displacement and strain on health and justice systems. Overdose has become a leading cause of death among young adults in parts of North America, while armed violence drives displacement in parts of Africa, Latin America and Asia.

- **Progress on the Sustainable Development Goals depends on it,** especially **SDG 3** (health, including target 3.5 on substance abuse) and **SDG 16** (peace and justice, including **target 16.4** on significantly reducing illicit financial and arms flows by 2030).

3.3 Why the Two Problems Are Treated Together

Drug markets and arms markets are different industries, but they share the **same weaknesses**: porous borders, corrupt officials, weak customs, poor data sharing and unregulated online spaces. A route that moves tablets can move weapon parts. **Profits from drugs buy guns, and guns protect drug profits.** Treating them separately means states solve half of a connected problem, which is why UNODC, with its mandate across drugs, crime and corruption, is the right forum.

Researchers often describe this as **crime convergence**. The connection appears in at least four ways:

- **Shared logistics.** The same smugglers, vehicles, shipping containers, postal channels and corrupt contacts are used for different goods. Border agencies have repeatedly reported drugs and weapons concealed in the same consignments, or moved by the same networks on alternating trips.
- **Shared finance.** Drug revenues are among the largest sources of income for organized crime and armed groups. That income is used to buy weapons, pay fighters and bribe officials, which in turn protects the drug business.
- **Drugs-for-guns exchange.** In some regions, drugs are traded directly for weapons, or weapons are accepted as payment for trafficking services. This removes the need for cash and makes financial tracing harder.
- **Shared enablers.** Both markets rely on the same gaps: weak record keeping, limited international data sharing, anonymous online marketplaces, encrypted messaging and lightly regulated payment methods.

Because of this, the international community has increasingly linked the two issues. Security Council resolutions on small arms have repeatedly noted the connection between illicit weapons and drug trafficking, and UNODC's firearms research has documented drugs and firearms seized together. A resolution that builds **joint mechanisms**, such as combined border units, shared databases and integrated financial investigations, will reflect this reality better than two separate sets of clauses.

3.4 Why Synthetic Drugs Are a Distinct Challenge

- **No land needed.** Unlike opium poppy or coca, synthetics can be produced in small, movable labs close to the consumer market. Labs can be dismantled and rebuilt elsewhere within days.
- **Fast innovation.** Producers can change a chemical formula to stay ahead of the law. When one substance is scheduled, a close variant often appears on the market soon after, which places constant pressure on national and international scheduling systems.

- **High potency.** Very small quantities, especially of synthetic opioids, carry large profits and large risks, and are easy to hide in ordinary parcels. A shipment small enough to fit in an envelope can contain thousands of doses.
- **Supply chain complexity.** Precursors may come from one country, be processed in a second and sold in a third. Many precursors are **dual-use chemicals** produced by legitimate industries, so the challenge is to stop diversion without disrupting lawful trade in pharmaceuticals, plastics, perfumes or agriculture.
- **Health impact.** Unpredictable strength and counterfeit pills increase the risk of overdose, including for people who did not know what they were taking. Users who believe they are buying a prescription painkiller, a sedative or a stimulant may unknowingly consume a synthetic opioid.
- **Low cost of entry.** Online marketplaces, encrypted applications and cryptocurrency allow small groups to buy chemicals, equipment and even production instructions, and to sell directly to consumers through the postal system.

3.5 Why Illicit Firearms Are a Distinct Challenge

- **Long lifespan.** A firearm can pass through many hands over decades, so past leaks keep causing harm today. Weapons from conflicts that ended many years ago still circulate in criminal markets.
- **Many sources.** Weapons enter illicit markets through theft, corruption, conflict leakage and homemade production. Unlike drugs, most illicit firearms **began their life as legal products**, which is why marking, record keeping and stockpile security matter so much.
- **Hard to trace.** Missing serial numbers, poor records and limited cross-border data sharing break the chain from maker to crime scene. Without tracing, investigators cannot identify where a weapon was diverted and cannot close the leak.
- **New technology.** Home manufacturing, online blueprints and parts sold separately challenge traditional licensing systems. Many legal systems control a complete firearm but not each of its components, which creates loopholes.
- **Ammunition and parts.** A weapon without ammunition is useless, yet ammunition is often less tightly controlled and harder to mark. Essential components such as barrels, slides and receivers can be shipped separately and assembled at destination.
- **Political sensitivity.** Civilian gun ownership, arms exports and national defence are areas where states guard their sovereignty closely. Consensus on firearms is therefore often harder to achieve than on drugs.

3.6 Scope of the Debate

To keep the debate focused, delegates are encouraged to concentrate on the following areas:

1. **Precursor control:** monitoring, pre-export notifications, industry partnerships and the scheduling of new precursors and designer precursors.
2. **Detection and early warning:** forensic capacity, drug-checking data, and faster identification and scheduling of new psychoactive substances.

3. **Firearms marking, record keeping and tracing,** including how to deal with ghost guns, converted weapons and 3D-printed components.
4. **Border, port, postal and customs security,** especially for developing and transit states with limited resources.
5. **Financial investigation:** money laundering, asset recovery and the use of cryptocurrency by trafficking networks.
6. **Public health responses:** prevention, treatment, overdose response and harm reduction, which reduce demand and save lives.
7. **Conflict and post-conflict settings:** stockpile management, disarmament and stopping armed groups from profiting from drug production.

Debates on the **legalisation of drugs**, on **domestic gun ownership laws** of individual states, or on **inter-state arms sales** in general are outside the core of this agenda and should be raised only where they directly affect trafficking or illicit production.

3.7 Key Stakeholders and Blocs

Positions in this committee are shaped less by traditional geopolitical blocs and more by **where a state sits in the supply chain**. Delegates should identify which of the following categories apply to their country, since many states fall into more than one:

- **Production states:** countries where synthetic drugs are manufactured at scale, often in areas outside full government control. Their priorities usually include sovereignty, development assistance and recognition of the role of external demand and external precursor supply.
- **Precursor-supplying states:** countries with large chemical and pharmaceutical industries. They tend to favour cooperation and voluntary industry measures over broad controls that could harm legitimate trade.
- **Transit states:** countries through which drugs and weapons pass. They often face violence and corruption without being the main producer or consumer, and frequently seek capacity building, equipment and burden-sharing.
- **Destination and consumer states:** countries facing high drug use and overdose deaths. Their focus is usually on supply-side enforcement, precursor control and public health.
- **Firearms-exporting and source states:** countries whose legal markets are a source of trafficked weapons. Debates over **export controls, civilian market regulation and legal responsibility** are often sensitive for them.
- **Conflict-affected states:** countries where weapons leak from stockpiles or battlefields and where armed groups fund themselves through trafficking. They usually need support for stockpile security, disarmament and governance.

Regional organisations such as the **African Union, ASEAN, the European Union, the Organization of American States and the League of Arab States**, as well as **INTERPOL, the World Customs Organization and the Financial Action Task Force (FATF)**, are important partners, and resolutions that make use of their existing structures will be more realistic.

4. Key Terms

- **Synthetic drugs:** drugs made chemically in labs rather than grown from plants. Examples include methamphetamine, amphetamine-type stimulants (ATS), synthetic opioids such as fentanyl, and new psychoactive substances (NPS).
- **Amphetamine-type stimulants (ATS):** a group of synthetic stimulants that includes amphetamine, methamphetamine and ecstasy-type substances.
- **Captagon:** originally a brand name for the pharmaceutical fenethylline. Today the term mostly refers to illicit amphetamine tablets, often counterfeit, sold widely in the Middle East.
- **Precursors:** chemicals used to manufacture drugs. Many have legitimate industrial uses, which complicates control.
- **Pre-precursors / designer precursors:** chemicals altered or substituted to avoid existing legal controls.
- **New Psychoactive Substances (NPS):** substances designed to mimic controlled drugs while staying outside the law, at least temporarily.
- **Clandestine laboratory:** an illegal facility for producing drugs.
- **Scheduling:** the process of placing a substance under international or national control, which determines how strictly it is regulated.
- **Ghost guns:** firearms without serial numbers, often assembled from kits or parts, making them hard to trace.
- **3D-printed firearms:** weapons or components produced by additive manufacturing.
- **Converted weapons:** blank-firing, alarm, gas or replica weapons modified to fire live ammunition.
- **Tracing:** tracking a firearm from manufacture or import through to its point of illicit use.
- **Diversion:** when legally produced or sold weapons or chemicals move into the illicit market.
- **Straw purchase:** the purchase of a firearm by a person who is legally allowed to buy it, on behalf of someone who is not.
- **End-user certificate:** an official document stating who the final recipient of an arms transfer will be; falsified certificates are a common diversion method.
- **Dual-use:** items with both legitimate and illicit applications.
- **Money laundering:** disguising the origin of criminal proceeds.
- **Harm reduction:** public health measures that reduce the negative consequences of drug use, such as overdose prevention and drug-checking services.

5. Historical Background

5.1 Drug Control

- **1961 Single Convention on Narcotic Drugs (amended 1972):** the foundation of the modern system, focused on plant-based narcotics. [18]
- **1971 Convention on Psychotropic Substances:** extended control to many synthetic drugs such as amphetamines. [19]
- **1988 UN Convention against Illicit Traffic in Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances:** targeted trafficking, money laundering and precursor chemicals (Article 12 and Tables I and II). [20]
- The **Commission on Narcotic Drugs (CND)** and the **International Narcotics Control Board (INCB)** oversee scheduling and monitoring. New substances are added to schedules over time, but the pace of new synthetic drugs often outruns the legal process.

5.2 Organized Crime and Firearms

- **UNTOC (2000)** entered into force in 2003 and is the main global instrument against organized crime. [21]
- **Firearms Protocol (2001)** entered into force in 2005. It is the **principal global legally binding instrument specifically addressing illicit firearms manufacture and trafficking**. It requires marking, record keeping, licensing for import and export, and criminalisation of illicit manufacturing and trafficking. [22, 27]
- **UN Programme of Action on Small Arms and Light Weapons (2001)** and the **International Tracing Instrument (2005)** are both **non-legally binding** frameworks on small arms control and tracing. States commit to implement them, but they are not treaties and do not create legal obligations under international law. [24, 25, 26, 28, 29]
- **Arms Trade Treaty (2013)** is a legally binding treaty, in force since 2014, that regulates the international trade in conventional arms, including small arms and light weapons, their ammunition, and parts and components. Several major arms-producing and importing states are not parties. [23, 27]

5.3 How the Synthetic Drug Market Grew

The market shifted from plant-based drugs toward synthetics over the last two decades. **Methamphetamine seizures have reached record levels in East and Southeast Asia** and expanded in other regions. **Fentanyl and other synthetic opioids have driven overdose crises,** especially in North America. **Captagon has become a major regional issue in the Middle East.** Online marketplaces, encrypted messaging and cryptocurrency have lowered barriers for traffickers.

6. Current Situation

6.1 Global Overview

According to UNODC's **World Drug Report 2026** (released on 26 June 2026), an estimated **331 million people** used a drug in 2024, or 6.2 per cent of the global population aged 15–64, up from 5.2 per cent in 2014. [2] Cannabis remains by far the most widely used drug, followed by opioids (63 million people) and amphetamines (32 million), and only **one in 12 people with drug use disorders is in treatment**. [2, 3] Synthetic drugs account for a growing share of both supply and harm: the report finds **five times more drug types in seizures in 2024 than before 2000**, and warns that traffickers are exploiting technology and instability to introduce novel drugs, some of them more potent or dangerous than before. [2, 3] The most significant development of the past decade is that **the most dangerous drugs are now increasingly made in laboratories**, not grown in fields. This changes where production happens, how fast the market adapts and how enforcement must respond.

At the same time, the global stock of firearms is enormous. The **Small Arms Survey** has estimated that there are over **one billion firearms** in the world, the large majority of them held by civilians. Even a small rate of diversion from such a large pool supplies criminal markets for decades.

Key Developments at a Glance	
Methamphetamine	Record global ATS seizures of 604 tons in 2024, dominated by methamphetamine; East and Southeast Asia seized a record 349 tons in 2025; the market is expanding in South-West Asia and the Middle East [6, 15]
Synthetic opioids	North American overdose deaths began to fall in 2024; nitazenes (found in 37 countries since 2019) and orphines are spreading, notably in Europe [10, 11]
Captagon	Syrian laboratories dismantled since December 2024; seizures rose sharply in 2025 as stocks were released; methamphetamine increasingly takes hold in the Middle East [7]
NPS	Record 755 substances on the market in 2024, 118 of them new; close to 1,500 identified since 2005 [12]
Firearms	Diversion, conflict leakage, cross-border trafficking and untraceable home-made weapons

6.2 Synthetic Narcotics: Main Substance Groups

Methamphetamine and amphetamine-type stimulants. Produced in large volumes in **Mexico** and in the **Golden Triangle** region (Myanmar, Laos and Thailand), and increasingly elsewhere. Global ATS seizures reached a **record 604 tons in 2024**, dominated by methamphetamine, with the highest growth reported by emerging markets. [6, 8] East and Southeast Asia and North America remain the largest markets, although seizures in North America fell over 2021–2024 while those in East and Southeast Asia kept rising. [8] Reports

also point to growing methamphetamine production in **Afghanistan**, including from the ephedra plant, a trend that gained attention after the 2022 restrictions on opium poppy cultivation; UNODC notes that methamphetamine can be produced more covertly than opium, which may have limited the ban's effect on this market. [5] Methamphetamine is now the most widely trafficked synthetic drug in many regions, and falling prices in some markets suggest that supply is outpacing enforcement.

Synthetic opioids (fentanyl and analogues). Extremely potent, so small quantities are easy to smuggle. Precursor chemicals often originate in industrial supply chains and are trafficked to labs, with finished products moving to consumer markets. They also appear pressed into **counterfeit pills** made to look like prescription medicines. Fentanyls still account for the largest share of harm from synthetic opioids, particularly in North America, where opioid overdose deaths peaked between 2021 and 2023 and have since declined, returning to pre-2020 levels in the United States but not in Canada. [11, 10] A newer concern is the **nitazenes and orphines**, synthetic opioids that are often more potent than fentanyl. Since isotonitazene was first reported in 2019, at least 34 nitazenes have been identified across 37 countries, and in 2024 alone 29 countries reported nitazenes on their markets, compared with 18 reporting fentanyl analogues. [11] Other substances, such as the veterinary sedative **xylazine**, are increasingly mixed with opioids, complicating overdose treatment.

Captagon. Produced largely in the Levant, with **Syria and Lebanon** identified as the main production hubs; the Near and Middle East accounted for 77 per cent of global "captagon" seizures in 2020–2024. [7] **Saudi Arabia and other Gulf states** are major destination markets, and **Jordan and Iraq** are important transit countries. The change of government in Syria in late 2024 transformed the market: according to the Syrian authorities, 16 laboratories, mostly of industrial scale, and 15 storage facilities have been dismantled, while the release of existing stocks produced a strong rise in seizures in Syria and Lebanon in 2025. UNODC warns that production may move to other countries and that methamphetamine is increasingly taking hold in the Middle East. [7, 5]

New psychoactive substances (NPS). A record **755 NPS were on the global market in 2024**, up from 582 in 2023, and 118 substances emerged that year; since 2005, close to 1,500 NPS have been identified by Member States, more than four times the number of substances under international control. Preliminary data do not suggest that the upward trend continued in 2025. [12] NPS are produced quickly, often sold online, and may be marketed as "legal highs" or "research chemicals". The market is in constant flux: 232 substances identified earlier were no longer reported on the market over 2019–2024, but some, such as synthetic cannabinoids and synthetic cathinones, have become established. [12]

Pharmaceutical opioids sold illicitly. Tramadol, a synthetic opioid that is not under international control, is widely misused in parts of **West, Central and North Africa and the Middle East**. Unregistered high-dose tablets are trafficked in large volumes, showing how gaps between national and international controls can be exploited. Trafficking in and misuse of pharmaceutical opioids reached record levels in 2024; Africa accounted for 60 per cent of the volume seized in 2020–2024 (mostly West and Central Africa) and Asia for 33 per cent, and

West and Central Africa alone accounted for 98 per cent of the tramadol seized in 2019–2024. [13]

6.3 Precursor Chemicals: The Key Choke Point

Because synthetic drugs require chemicals rather than crops, **precursor control is the closest equivalent to crop eradication**. The **INCB** coordinates international monitoring through tools such as **PEN Online** (pre-export notifications between governments) and **PICS** (the Precursors Incident Communication System), which allows authorities to share information on suspicious shipments in real time.

Traffickers have responded by turning to **non-scheduled chemicals and designer precursors**, which are not under control and can be converted into controlled precursors after import. Each time a precursor is scheduled, suppliers shift to the next uncontrolled chemical. This has led to growing interest in **voluntary partnerships with the chemical industry, "know-your-customer" practices, and broader or generic control approaches** that cover whole families of chemicals rather than single substances. UNODC data show how far traffickers have adapted: between 2014 and 2024 global methamphetamine seizures tripled, yet the quantities of methamphetamine precursors intercepted fell by 85 per cent and the number of dismantled methamphetamine laboratories fell by 94 per cent, consistent with a shift towards large-scale “super labs”. [9, 6]

6.4 Illicit Firearms: Main Sources

- **Diversion from legal markets:** theft from stockpiles, falsified end-user certificates, corrupt officials and lax licensing.
- **Leakage from conflict zones:** weapons left over from wars flow to criminal and armed groups. The **Sahel, Libya** and other regions have been affected, and there is concern about the long-term fate of weapons supplied to current conflicts.
- **Cross-border trafficking:** flows of firearms from high-supply markets into countries with strong organized crime, such as along the **US-Mexico border**. This often takes the form of many small shipments ("ant trade") rather than large consignments.
- **Illicit and untraceable manufacture:** ghost guns, homemade guns, **converted blank-firing or replica weapons**, and **3D-printed components**. Converted weapons have become a significant problem in Europe, while 3D-printed firearms have been reported in Europe, North America, Australia and conflict zones such as Myanmar.
- **Online sales and postal shipments:** smaller consignments, often of parts, that evade bulk-shipment checks.

UNODC's **Global Study on Firearms Trafficking** has found that a large share of seized firearms are seized in connection with other crimes, with **drug trafficking among the most frequently associated offences**. This confirms the link at the heart of this agenda.

6.5 Emerging Trends

- **Digital marketplaces:** darknet markets, social media and encrypted messaging applications are used to advertise drugs, chemicals and weapon parts.

- **Cryptocurrency:** digital assets are used to pay suppliers and launder proceeds. The FATF has extended its standards to virtual asset service providers, but implementation varies widely between states.
- **Postal and express courier networks:** small, high-value parcels are difficult to inspect at scale.
- **Crime convergence in conflict zones:** armed groups in several regions combine drug production, arms trafficking, extortion and other crimes, such as online scam operations.

6.6 Current International Responses

- **UNODC Synthetic Drug Strategy:** launched in 2021 to support early warning, forensic capacity, precursor control and public health responses.
- **CND scheduling decisions:** in recent years the CND has placed several fentanyl precursors and a number of nitazenes and other NPS under international control. At its 69th session in March 2026, the CND placed three further NPS under international control. [17]
- **UNODC Global Firearms Programme:** supports states in legislation, marking, record keeping, tracing and investigations, and in implementing the Firearms Protocol.
- **UNODC-WCO Container Control Programme and AIRCOP:** train port and airport units to profile and inspect high-risk cargo and passengers.
- **Global Coalition to Address Synthetic Drug Threats:** launched in 2023 by the United States and joined by many states and organisations.
- **INTERPOL tools:** including the **iARMS** database of lost and stolen firearms and operations against drug and weapons trafficking.

Note: figures in this guide have been refreshed against the UNODC World Drug Report 2026 (released 26 June 2026) and the UNODC regional report Synthetic Drugs in East and Southeast Asia 2026 (12 June 2026). Numbers in square brackets refer to the Bibliography in Section 10. Figures change every year, so delegates should check the latest editions of the World Drug Report, INCB reports and the Global Study on Firearms Trafficking before committee.

7. Case Studies

Case Study 1: Captagon in the Levant and the Gulf

At a Glance	
Region	Syria, Lebanon, Jordan, Iraq, Saudi Arabia and the Gulf; transit via Europe and North Africa
Substance	Illicit amphetamine tablets sold as "Captagon"
Firearms link	Armed smuggling networks; weapons and drugs seized together on the Syria-Jordan border
Key responses	Border interdiction, US and UK sanctions, Arab diplomatic engagement

Background

Captagon was originally a brand name for the pharmaceutical **fenethylline**, developed in the 1960s to treat conditions such as attention disorders and narcolepsy. It was brought under international control in the 1980s and legitimate production effectively ended. Today the name is used for **illicit tablets that usually contain amphetamine**, often mixed with caffeine and other fillers, and frequently stamped with the original product's distinctive logo. The tablets are cheap, easy to produce in simple labs and easy to press in large volumes, which makes them a **high-profit product**.

Captagon is consumed across the Middle East, both recreationally and, according to some reports, by fighters and labourers seeking to stay awake and suppress hunger. Its social image as a relatively harmless stimulant has helped it spread among young people in the Gulf.

Production and Routes

Syria has been widely identified by governments and researchers as the main production hub, particularly during the civil war, when the collapse of the formal economy and the presence of armed actors created ideal conditions. Production was also reported in Lebanon's Bekaa Valley. Some research estimates have placed the value of the trade in the **billions of US dollars per year**, larger than many of the region's legal exports, although such figures are difficult to verify.

Tablets move through **Lebanon, Jordan and Iraq**, and by sea, towards Gulf markets, with **Saudi Arabia reported as the largest destination**. Smugglers have hidden pills in fruit, vegetables, furniture, industrial machinery and even pallets. Captagon has also turned up in Europe, used as a transit point to disguise origin: in **2020, Italian authorities reported a seizure of around 14 tonnes at the port of Salerno**, said to be one of the largest amphetamine seizures in history. Shipments have also been intercepted in and around Libya, Greece and other Mediterranean states.

Impact

The trade has **fuelled drug use in the Gulf**, produced **violent clashes between smugglers and border forces**, especially on the **Jordanian border**, and raised diplomatic tension. Jordanian

authorities have reported smugglers crossing in armed groups and have seized **weapons and explosives alongside drugs**, a clear example of the drugs-firearms link. Jordan tightened its rules of engagement on the border and has been reported to carry out strikes against smuggling networks inside southern Syria.

In **2021, Saudi Arabia suspended imports of Lebanese produce** after a large shipment of tablets was found hidden in pomegranates, hurting Lebanese farmers at a time of deep economic crisis. This shows how trafficking can damage **legitimate trade** and innocent producers.

Responses So Far

- **Interdiction:** Jordan and Saudi Arabia have strengthened border security, surveillance and inspection, and Gulf states regularly report large seizures.
- **Sanctions:** the **United States and United Kingdom** imposed sanctions in 2023 on individuals linked to the trade, including relatives of the former Syrian leadership and Lebanese-based traffickers. The US also passed legislation requiring a strategy to disrupt the trade.
- **Diplomacy:** when Arab states re-engaged with Damascus in 2023, including Syria's return to the League of Arab States, **counter-Captagon commitments were part of the discussions**.
- **Political change in Syria:** after the fall of the previous government in **December 2024**, the new authorities displayed and destroyed stockpiles and reported discovering production sites. The World Drug Report 2026 records that, according to the Syrian authorities, **16 laboratories, mostly of industrial scale, and 15 storage facilities have been dismantled**, and that this, together with the release of stocks onto the market, led to a strong increase in seizures in Syria and Lebanon in 2025. [7] UNODC cautions that the long-term effect on the global market remains to be seen, that production could move to other countries in the region and beyond, and that **methamphetamine is increasingly taking hold in the Middle East** as “captagon” supply declines. [7, 5]

Why It Is Hard to Solve

There are **no crops to eradicate**, labs are small and mobile, and **armed groups and corrupt officials are reported to have profited** from the trade. Amphetamine is already internationally controlled, so **the gap is in enforcement, precursor monitoring and regional intelligence sharing rather than in the law**. Transit states such as Jordan carry heavy costs while having limited control over production on the other side of the border. Political disagreements over Syria have also limited formal regional cooperation.

Relevance to the Committee

Captagon shows how a **conflict economy** can turn a cheap synthetic drug into a strategic industry, how smuggling networks combine drugs and weapons, and how transit and destination states can be left to bear the burden. It also tests whether UNODC can support cooperation in a region where political trust is low. It also shows how disrupting one product can displace a market rather than end it, as methamphetamine begins to fill the gap. [7]

Questions for Delegates

1. How can transit states be supported without harming legitimate trade?
2. What role can regional bodies and UNODC play in joint border and port operations?
3. How should the committee handle a trade linked to a conflict where governments disagree?
4. How can the international community help a post-conflict government replace a drug economy with legitimate livelihoods?

Case Study 2: Fentanyl and Firearms between Mexico and the United States

At a Glance	
Region	Mexico, United States and Canada; precursor supply from Asia
Substance	Fentanyl and analogues, often pressed into counterfeit pills; also methamphetamine
Firearms link	Drugs flow north, firearms flow south across the same border
Key responses	Precursor scheduling, China's 2019 class-wide control, bilateral security cooperation

Background

Fentanyl is a very potent synthetic opioid, many times stronger than morphine and heroin, and a very small amount can be fatal. It has legitimate medical uses in anaesthesia and pain relief, but illicitly made fentanyl now dominates the North American opioid market. **Precursor chemicals are reported to be sourced from chemical suppliers abroad, particularly in Asia,** then synthesised by criminal groups in Mexican labs and pressed into **counterfeit pills** or mixed into other drugs. Many buyers do not know the pills contain fentanyl, which raises the risk of overdose.

The main trafficking organisations named by authorities are Mexican groups such as the **Sinaloa Cartel** and the **Cartel Jalisco Nueva Generación (CJNG)**. Precursors typically arrive through Pacific ports, labs are often small, and finished products are smuggled into the United States mostly through official ports of entry, hidden in vehicles and cargo.

Impact on the Drug Side

Synthetic opioids have become a **leading cause of overdose deaths in the United States**, with **annual overdose deaths above 100,000 in 2022 and 2023**, the majority involving synthetic opioids. The World Drug Report 2026 finds that opioid overdose deaths reached historical highs in the United States and Canada between 2021 and 2023 and have since **started to decline**, returning to pre-2020 levels in the United States but not in Canada, where fentanyl analogues may be partly replacing fentanyl in overdose deaths. [10] UNODC notes that deaths linked to illicitly produced fentanyls fell in North America in 2024 for the first time in a decade. [4] Experts link the decline to a combination of factors including wider availability of the overdose-reversal medicine naloxone, changes in the drug supply and enforcement. **Canada has also seen serious harm,** with tens of thousands of opioid-related deaths since 2016. The crisis has strained hospitals, emergency services, child welfare systems and workplaces.

The Firearms Side

Firearms flow in the opposite direction. Officials in Mexico and the United States have reported that a **large share of the firearms recovered at Mexican crime scenes and traced can be linked back to the United States**; a 2021 US Government Accountability Office report found that around **70 percent** of firearms seized in Mexico and traced between 2014 and 2018 originated in the US. Weapons are typically obtained through **straw purchases** and smuggled

across the land border in small quantities. Mexico, by contrast, has **very strict domestic gun laws** and only one legal gun store, run by the military.

These weapons arm criminal groups, **raise homicide levels** and weaken state control in some regions. Firearms are used in a large majority of homicides in Mexico, and cartels have acquired high-calibre rifles capable of outgunning local police.

Legal and Policy Responses

- **Precursor controls: China introduced class-wide controls on fentanyl-type substances in 2019**, after which trafficking shifted more toward precursors. The **CND** placed key fentanyl precursors under international control in 2017 and added further precursors in 2022.
- **Litigation:** Mexico sued US firearm manufacturers in US courts, arguing that their practices facilitated trafficking. In **2025 the US Supreme Court ruled unanimously against Mexico**, holding that US federal law shields manufacturers from such claims.
- **US domestic measures:** the **Bipartisan Safer Communities Act (2022)** created specific federal offences for straw purchasing and firearms trafficking, and federal rules on ghost gun kits were upheld by the US Supreme Court in 2025.
- **Bilateral cooperation:** the two countries have run long-standing security cooperation programmes, from the **Mérida Initiative (2008)** to the **Bicentennial Framework (2021)**, with changing levels of trust. In 2025, the United States designated several Mexican cartels as **Foreign Terrorist Organizations** and linked trade measures to fentanyl flows, while Mexico increased deployments at the border and transferred alleged cartel figures to US custody.

Why It Is Hard to Solve

Precursors have legitimate uses, so tight controls affect legal industry. **Fentanyl is so potent that tiny shipments carry huge value,** making interdiction extremely difficult. On firearms, **states disagree over legal responsibility**, and civilian gun ownership is politically sensitive. Both countries also have strong concerns about **sovereignty**, which limits joint operations. Finally, the problem is driven by **demand** as well as supply, which means public health responses are essential.

Relevance to the Committee

This case is the clearest example of a **two-way trafficking relationship**: drugs in one direction, guns in the other. It raises the central question of **shared responsibility** between producer, transit, source and consumer states, and shows why precursor control, firearms tracing and public health must be addressed together.

Questions for Delegates

1. Who is responsible for controlling exports of precursors and firearms?
2. How can seizure and tracing data be shared faster and more reliably?
3. How can the committee support affected communities and health systems?
4. How can cooperation be deepened while respecting each state's sovereignty?

Case Study 3: Methamphetamine in the Golden Triangle

At a Glance	
Region	Myanmar (Shan State), Laos, Thailand; markets across East and Southeast Asia, South Asia and Oceania
Substance	Methamphetamine tablets ("yaba") and crystal methamphetamine; also ketamine
Firearms link	Armed groups controlling production areas; weapons circulating along the same routes
Key responses	Mekong MOU (1993), ASEAN cooperation, UNODC Border Liaison Offices

Background

The border area between **Myanmar, Laos and Thailand**, centred on **Myanmar's Shan State**, was long known for opium. Over the past two decades it has become **one of the world's largest centres for methamphetamine production**, in the form of pills (often called **yaba**) and **crystal methamphetamine**. Production has moved from small kitchen labs to **industrial-scale facilities** capable of producing large volumes at low cost.

Shan State is home to numerous **ethnic armed organisations and government-aligned militias**, many of which control territory where the central government has little authority. This combination of conflict, weak state presence and easy access to chemicals across nearby borders has made the region ideal for synthetic drug production.

Scale of the Problem

UNODC's regional reports have recorded **record methamphetamine seizures across East and Southeast Asia** in successive years: 236 tonnes in 2024 and **349 tonnes in 2025**, a 48 per cent increase on the previous record and more than five times the amount seized a decade earlier. [15, 16] The region accounted for 48 per cent of all methamphetamine seized worldwide in 2024, [8] and about 94 per cent of the regional total in 2025 was seized in Southeast Asia. [14] Seizures of ketamine also reached a record high in 2025. [15] Seizures are only part of the picture: UNODC officials stress that much more methamphetamine is reaching the market. [16] At the same time, **street prices have fallen** in many markets, a sign that supply remains abundant despite enforcement. Seizures have also risen in **South Asia**, including Bangladesh and north-eastern India, and in the Pacific.

In **2020**, a series of operations in northern Shan State, described by UNODC as **among the largest synthetic drug operations in Asia's history**, recovered close to **200 million methamphetamine tablets**, large amounts of crystal methamphetamine and very large quantities of precursor chemicals. Even so, production continued.

Routes and Markets

Drugs move through **Thailand, Laos, Vietnam and China** to markets in Southeast Asia, East Asia and beyond, including **Japan, South Korea and Australia**. Increasingly, shipments also go by sea through the Andaman Sea and the Strait of Malacca, and west into Bangladesh and

India. **Precursor chemicals are reported to be brought into the region from outside,** which makes precursor control a key part of the response. Traffickers have increasingly turned to **non-controlled chemicals** to avoid detection.

The Conflict Link

Instability in Myanmar, including after the 2021 military takeover, has made enforcement harder in border areas. Armed groups, militias and local power-holders have been reported to profit from the trade, and **weapons circulate in the same areas**. Resistance groups and armed organisations have also used **3D-printed firearms** and locally manufactured weapons. In addition, criminal networks in the borderlands have been linked to **casinos, money laundering and large-scale online scam compounds**, showing how one illicit economy feeds another. This links the drug market and the arms market directly. UNODC's 2026 regional report points to a growing convergence between drug trafficking and other organized crime, particularly the region's online scam centres. [15] The World Drug Report 2026 also notes that opium production in Myanmar rose from 420 tons in 2021 to over 1,000 tons in 2025. [2]

Regional Response

- **Mekong MOU:** the six Mekong countries (**Cambodia, China, Laos, Myanmar, Thailand and Vietnam**) have cooperated under a drug control memorandum of understanding since **1993**, with UNODC support through its **regional office in Bangkok**.
- **Border Liaison Offices:** UNODC has helped establish cross-border offices where officials from neighbouring states share information and coordinate operations.
- **ASEAN cooperation:** ASEAN members have worked on joint operations, information sharing and regional work plans against illicit drugs.
- **Differing national approaches:** approaches to drug users differ widely between states, **from strict enforcement, including severe penalties in some countries, to health-based models** that treat drug use primarily as a public health issue.

Why It Is Hard to Solve

The main production areas are **outside full government control**, borders are **long and porous**, and the **profits are large compared to local legal incomes**. Communities in production areas often depend on the drug economy for work. Enforcement in one area tends to displace production to another, and cooperation with a government that lacks control over its own territory is politically complicated.

Relevance to the Committee

It shows how **conflict zones with armed groups can host industrial-scale synthetic drug production**, and how **one region's supply affects many consumer markets**. It also highlights the importance of **alternative development** and health-based responses alongside enforcement.

Questions for Delegates

1. How can regional cooperation work where one government has limited control over its border areas?
2. How can precursor flows into the region be stopped?

3. How can enforcement be balanced with health and development support?

Case Study 4: Arms Leakage from Libya and the Sahel

At a Glance	
Region	Libya, Mali, Niger, Chad, Burkina Faso and neighbouring states; spillover to Nigeria and beyond
Weapons	Small arms, light weapons and ammunition looted from state stockpiles after 2011
Drug link	Tramadol and other drugs moving along the same desert routes
Key responses	UN arms embargo and Panel of Experts, EU Operation IRINI, AU "Silencing the Guns"

Background

After the **collapse of the Libyan government in 2011**, large stockpiles of weapons accumulated over decades were **looted or left unsecured**, and weapons spread across North Africa and the Sahel. These stockpiles included huge numbers of rifles, machine guns, ammunition and even portable air-defence systems. The **UN Security Council imposed an arms embargo on Libya in 2011** (resolution 1970) and set up a **Panel of Experts** to monitor it. The panel has **repeatedly reported violations and continued flows**, and in 2021 described the embargo as "totally ineffective" given the scale of foreign supply to the parties in Libya's conflict.

Where the Weapons Went

Reports link Libyan weapons to conflicts and armed groups in **Mali, Niger, Chad** and neighbouring regions, and to wider insecurity reaching countries such as **Nigeria**. In 2012, fighters returning from Libya with weapons contributed to the rebellion in northern Mali, which was later exploited by extremist groups. **Small arms have a long life, so weapons from 2011 still feed violence today.** In more recent years, armed groups in the Sahel have also obtained weapons by **capturing them from national armies**, adding a new source of supply.

The Synthetic Drug Link

Trafficking routes through Libya and the Sahel are also used for other illicit goods. **UNODC and other bodies have flagged the movement of tramadol,** a synthetic opioid, through these routes towards **West and North Africa**, where non-medical use has become a major concern. High-dose tablets, often far stronger than those approved for medical use, have been produced mainly in **South Asia** and shipped to West African ports before moving inland. **Tramadol is not under international control**, which has made coordinated action harder, although several producing and importing countries have tightened national controls. The World Drug Report 2026 confirms how concentrated the problem is: West and Central Africa accounted for 98 per cent of the tramadol seized worldwide in 2019–2024, and seizures of pharmaceutical opioids reached record levels in 2024. [13]

Captagon seizures in and around Libya, as well as cocaine and cannabis resin trafficking across the region, show that the same corridors serve many markets. **Armed groups may tax or**

protect smuggling routes, which links arms and drug flows. Tramadol has also been reported to be used by some fighters, directly connecting the drug to armed violence.

Impact

The consequences include **insecurity, strengthened armed and extremist groups, displacement, weakened borders and heavier burdens on neighbouring states**. A series of military takeovers in **Mali, Burkina Faso and Niger** between 2020 and 2023, the withdrawal of the UN peacekeeping mission from Mali in 2023 and the reduction of international security partnerships have further weakened regional cooperation.

Responses So Far

- **The UN arms embargo and its monitoring panel** on Libya.
- **The European Union's naval operation** (Operation IRINI, launched in 2020) to help enforce the embargo at sea.
- **The African Union's "Silencing the Guns" initiative,** whose target date was extended from 2020 to 2030.
- **The ECOWAS Convention on Small Arms and Light Weapons (2006),** a legally binding regional instrument for West Africa.
- **UNODC and regional programmes** on border management, weapons marking, record keeping and stockpile security, including UNODC's Sahel Programme and Global Firearms Programme.

Why It Is Hard to Solve

Political division in Libya, with rival authorities, makes national enforcement difficult. The region has **very long desert borders**, **large numbers of weapons already in circulation**, and **limited resources for border and customs agencies** in affected states. Local communities may depend on cross-border trade, legal and illegal, for their livelihoods, and some armed groups provide services or security that the state does not.

Relevance to the Committee

It shows how **weak stockpile security after a conflict creates long-term supply for illicit markets**, and how **arms and synthetic drug trafficking can share the same corridors**. It also shows the limits of embargoes when they are not supported by monitoring, enforcement and regional capacity.

Questions for Delegates

1. How can stockpile management and weapons marking be funded and supported after conflicts?
2. How can states close the gap created by substances, such as tramadol, that are not under international control?
3. How can border communities be supported so they do not depend on smuggling economies?
4. How can UNODC work with regional bodies when political relations in the region are strained?

8. Questions a Resolution Must Answer

1. How can states **improve precursor monitoring** without hurting legitimate trade?
2. How can UNODC **speed up detection and scheduling** of new synthetic substances?
3. What mechanisms will **improve firearms tracing and information sharing**?
4. How can states address **ghost guns and 3D-printed weapons**?
5. How can **border, customs and port security** be strengthened, especially in developing states?
6. How should **financial flows and cryptocurrency** be tracked?
7. How will the solution **support public health**, including treatment and harm reduction?
8. **Who funds implementation,** and how is progress measured?
9. How do you **respect national sovereignty** while enabling cooperation?

9. Research Sources

Prioritise **authoritative sources**:

- **UNODC:** World Drug Report 2026 and its online Data Portal, Global SMART reports, Synthetic Drugs in East and Southeast Asia 2026, Global Study on Firearms Trafficking, and country and regional reports.
- **INCB** annual reports and precursor reports (precursors and treaty compliance).
- **UN Security Council and General Assembly** documents on small arms and drugs, including Panel of Experts reports.
- **EUDA** (European Union Drugs Agency), **INTERPOL** and the **World Customs Organization** reports.
- **Small Arms Survey** and **UNIDIR** for firearms research.
- **Your country's official statements, laws and treaty status** (UN Treaty Collection).

Note on Evidence in Committee

In keeping with the research-centric nature of this committee, the Executive Board will treat the following as **credible evidence**: official UN documents and reports, official government sources and statements, and reports from reputable international news agencies such as **Reuters**. Wikipedia, blogs and opinion pieces may help your background reading but **will not be accepted as evidence** in committee. Where facts are disputed, delegates should say so and present the source on which they rely.

10. Bibliography

Numbers in square brackets in the text refer to the entries below. Delegates are encouraged to go to the original documents and to cite them directly, in line with the evidence rules set out in Section 9. Online sources were last accessed in October 2026.

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